

Police as Policymakers: How Experiences With Policy Implementation Shape Policy Representation

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Abstract

Scholars of political representation have focused primarily on congruence between public preferences and enacted legislation, paying less attention to how policies are actually delivered by street-level bureaucrats in face-to-face encounters with citizens. This approach obscures the possibility that individuals may nonetheless have divergent perceptions of implemented policy that, in turn, inform their political attitudes. We examine this argument in the context of policing and traffic stops in Los Angeles using an integrated mixed-methods design combining an original survey ($N = 2,118$) and thirty semi-structured interviews. Our survey finds limited racial variation in preferences for police behavior and in reports of officer behavior during traffic stops. At the same time, our survey reproduces well-documented racial gaps in general assessments of police legitimacy and effectiveness. Our interviews reveal that these patterns result from fundamentally different personal and vicarious experiences across racial groups. For Black and Latine residents, the desire for a professional officer reflects concern for physical safety; for White residents, it reflects a preference for courtesy. Survey instruments that record responses but not the expectations underlying them may systematically understate racial inequality in how police encounters are actually experienced.

Keywords

policy representation, street-level bureaucracy, policing, mixed-methods research

Introduction

A foundational question in democratic theory is whether the government acts in accordance with citizens' preferences. Scholars of representation have long assessed this question by measuring congruence between public opinion and the policies that legislatures enact (Achen 1978; Erikson et al. 2002; Miller and Stokes 1963). This research program has a documented blind spot: it largely stops at enactment by the legislature and does not attend much to how the enacted policy is delivered to the citizens whose preferences are being represented. Yet policies enacted by legislatures must be implemented—often by street-level bureaucrats who exercise substantial discretion in deciding how, and how vigorously, to apply the law in individual cases (Lipsky 1980; Pepinsky et al. 2017). This discretion is not a small detail, as it affects the actual policy that people experience. Street-level bureaucrats make important judgments about who receives

services and on what terms (Maynard-Moody and Musheno 2003), and how citizens are treated affects beliefs about government responsiveness, trust in

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institutions, and political engagement (Mettler and Soss 2004; Soss 1999). In domains where the policy experienced by a citizen is largely affected by a government official in a face-to-face interaction, evaluating representation requires measuring what happens when the state encounters the public.

Policing is an especially important case. Traffic stops are among the most common points of contact between citizens and their government in the United States; they are also high-stakes interactions in which officer discretion is extensive, and the gap between written policy and enacted behavior can be substantial (Baumgartner et al. 2018; Epp et al. 2014). An extensive body of research has documented racial disparities in who gets stopped (Pierson et al. 2020) and, more recently, in how officers communicate during stops (Voigt et al. 2017). Studies using nationally representative surveys of citizens about their traffic stop experiences document that Black and Hispanic respondents report less favorable treatment than White respondents—including less respectful officer behavior, more frequent searches, and less perceived fairness (Engel and Calnon 2004; Epp et al. 2014; Langton and Durose 2013). Consistent with these patterns, research on public opinion has documented persistent and large racial gaps in general assessments of police: in trust, perceptions of legitimacy, and evaluations of performance (Lerman and Weaver 2014; Tyler 2005; Wheelock et al. 2019).

Against this backdrop, we designed an integrated mixed-methods study that uses large-N and small-N methods to study expectations and experiences with *police-as-government* in Los Angeles, the second-largest city in the United States, with the third-largest police department. We fielded an original survey of over 2,000 Los Angeles residents asking about (1) *preferences* for police behavior, (2) their recent *experiences* with traffic stops, and (3) their *perceptions* of policing as an institution. We find strikingly similar stated preferences across racial groups for how officers should behave during traffic stops. We ask about recent traffic stop experiences and find little racial variation in respondents' experiences of positive or negative officer behavior or in respondents' beliefs about whether their stop was legitimate—a pattern at odds with evidence that Black and Hispanic respondents rate stop-level treatment less favorably than White respondents (Epp et al. 2014). These results do not appear to be a result of our sample of respondents, as our survey reproduces other well-documented patterns in general assessments of police. This pattern of results raises the following question: why do racial groups in Los Angeles report homogenous preferences for police behavior, broadly similar experiences during individual stops, yet diverge so sharply in their general assessments of the police?

We suggest that survey-based methods fail to account for differences in expectations, fears, and accumulated histories that affect perceptions of police and ultimately the quality of policy representation. Interviews reveal that the desire for respectful, professional officer behavior—which appears uniform in our survey responses—is held against entirely different contexts of fear and exposure among Black and Latine residents compared to White residents, which emerged organically from the interviewees. For many Black and Latine interviewees, the preference for a calm officer reflects a desire that such behavior translates into their safety in the context of a plausible threat. For White interviewees, it reflects a preference for courtesy and respect during an inconvenient interaction. These different orientations towards police interactions can produce similar survey responses while reflecting fundamentally different views of policing and experiences (vicarious and direct) with *police-as-government*. The implication is that understanding representation and measuring inequality in policing requires attention not only to what officers do, but to what people bring to encounters, including the fear and prior exposure that shape how those encounters are interpreted and remembered.

The paper proceeds as follows. We first situate our argument in the literature on policy representation, street-level bureaucracy, and policing. We then describe our data and methods. We present survey results on preferences and reported experiences, followed by interview results on the role of expectations and prior exposure. We conclude by discussing implications for the study of racial inequality in policing and for the measurement of policy representation and implementation more broadly.

Representation and Implementation: Policing and Public Opinion

The literature on policy representation investigates whether and to what degree public preferences are reflected in public policy, usually focusing on (in)congruence between public opinion and policy positions, ideological priorities, or actions taken by elected representatives and their parties (Bafumi and Herron 2010; Dalton et al. 2011; Miller and Stokes 1963). As noted by Wlezien (2017, 562), however, “positions, priorities, and policies are different things.”

This distinction is particularly salient in domains where policy is implemented by street-level bureaucrats (SLBs) who operate with high degrees of discretion (Lipsky 1980). Whether through the action of welfare workers, teachers, or counselors (Maynard-Moody and Musheno 2003; Soss et al. 2011) the content and quality

of SLB-public interactions inform how people understand the state's goals, its functions, and how it values one's social group (T. B. Pepinsky et al. 2017, 261–62; Soss et al. 2011). SLBs' discretion decides “which children are educated and how, who receives life-saving medication or an identity card, who is fined or arrested for violating a law or regulation, and who pays how much in taxes” (T. B. Pepinsky et al. 2017, 257). The content of interactions with SLBs affects the likelihood of people accepting their decisions (Kang 2022), and can either build or erode trust in the wider governance structures that SLBs represent (Davidovitz and Cohen 2022; Gershgoren and Cohen 2023; Kumlin and Rothstein 2005). The final stage in the “chain of representation” then, is not just the written content of policy, but rather its interpretation and implementation by bureaucratic actors (Dahl 1966; Rohrschneider and Thomassen 2020).

Police are prototypical street-level bureaucrats, operating with wide discretion and little direct oversight during their interactions with the public (Bittner 1970; Lipsky 1980). While this discretion is vital to delivering police services in uncertain and resource-constrained conditions (Bittner 1967; H. E. Pepinsky 1984), it also allows for disparate treatment of those contacted by officers. Such treatment is especially consequential for the public's relationship with the state, because police are its most visible, contacted, and coercive representatives, especially in “race-class subjugated communities” that experience high levels of police contact (Soss and Weaver 2017).

Building on research that documents pervasive inequalities in who is stopped, searched, arrested, and subjected to police violence (Epp et al. 2014; Gaston 2019; Kramer and Remster 2018; Pierson et al. 2020), a growing literature attends to the political consequences of contact with police. Whereas positive, respectful interactions with police can improve community perceptions of police and willingness to cooperate with them (Peyton et al. 2019), police interactions experienced as disrespectful, unfair, or brutal increase distrust, fear, and perceived illegitimacy of police (Carr et al. 2007; Meares et al. 2015; Pickett et al. 2022; Sunshine and Tyler 2003). These experiences constitute a coercive civic education that informs distrust of a state that is simultaneously overly punitive and unresponsive to the needs of poor, minority communities (Lerman and Weaver 2014; Prowse et al. 2020).

Crucially, the interactions that inform people's relationship with police and the wider state can be either direct—for example, being respected, disrespected, or brutalized during a traffic stop—or vicarious—learning of others' poor treatment by police (Brunson 2007).¹ Such experiences accumulate over time and inform feelings of fear, anxiety, and distrust, especially among

Black Americans (Pickett et al. 2022). As in social interactions more broadly (Forgas et al. 1984), these emotions affect individuals' perceptions of police and their expectations about future contact (Deckard et al. 2025).² Clevinger et al. (2018) document such feelings and show that Black participants who were more concerned with being negatively perceived by police reported feeling less safe when in the presence of police.

However, existing research provides an insufficient view of the public's preferences for, experiences with, and perceptions of policing, especially as they pertain to democratic representation. While fear of police and highly-publicized police killings of Black people predict greater support for broad policies such as “defunding” or “abolishing” the police (Morris and Shoub 2024; Pickett et al. 2022), this says little about the public's views on policies germane to the content of an actual, common interaction with a police officer such as a traffic stop.

The Present Study: Preferences, Experiences, and Implementation in Traffic Stops in Los Angeles

We assess Los Angeles residents' preferences for, experiences with, and perceptions of the most common police-public interaction in the United States: traffic stops. Police perform some 20 million traffic stops every year (Open Policing Project 2023). As in other types of police contact (Gelman et al. 2007; Kochel et al. 2011; Kramer and Remster 2018; Morrow et al. 2017), racial disparities in traffic stops are well documented. Black people are more likely than others to be stopped, searched, arrested, and assaulted in the context of traffic stops (Baumgartner et al. 2018; Epp et al. 2014; Glaser 2015; Pierson et al. 2020).

We expand on prior research about policy representation by capturing policy preferences relevant to interactions with SLBs, people's perceptions of SLB behavior, and prior experience with SLBs. To do so, we collect and analyze a unique combination of survey and interview data to assess variation across racial groups in preferences, experiences, and expectations regarding police traffic stops in Los Angeles. We use an intentionally integrated mixed-method research design in which the research methods shed light on different, but related, elements of the overall theoretical argument (Seawright 2016; Weller and Barnes 2014). This approach allows us to use each research method for its best purposes. Our large-N survey is useful for describing broad patterns across Los Angeles residents, and we use surveys of over 2,000 Los Angeles residents to identify preferences and variation across racial groups with respect to officer conduct during traffic stops, personal experiences with

traffic stops, and overall perceptions of police performance and legitimacy. We use our 30 semi-structured interviews to contextualize and better understand the survey results about individuals' personal and vicarious experiences with police, as well as the expectations with which they enter traffic stop interactions. Taken together, the two data sources allow us to draw conclusions that neither data source would support on its own.³

Survey Methods

Our survey was fielded in two waves during November 2023 and June 2024 through PrimePanels by Cloud Research, which recruited respondents from a provided list of Los Angeles city ZIP codes.⁴ Because our goal is to understand the opinions of all Los Angeles residents, we did not attempt to draw a representative sample of voters, but instead recruited residents based on living in a Los Angeles city ZIP code and then weighted our sample to match the demographics of Los Angeles residents based on age, race, and education from the U.S. Census (U.S. Census Bureau 2022). In total, we document the responses of 2,118 Angelenos, composed of 1,173 respondents from the November wave and 945 respondents from the June wave.

To assess preferences for police actions during traffic stops, we provided survey respondents with an open-ended question using the following prompt.

For the next two questions we would like you to think about an interaction between you and a police officer during a normal traffic stop. For example, imagine you have been pulled over for speeding on a local road. Please answer the following questions about communication with the officer during the interaction.

Please describe how you would [NOT] like the officer to communicate with you. Feel free to include specific words or tone you would [not] like the officer to use:

We followed up the questions about communication with a pair of questions asking respondents to "Please describe any **actions** you would [NOT] like/want the officer to take during the traffic stop."

To analyze these responses, we conducted a series of preprocessing steps to ensure consistency and reliability.⁵ We then take the positive and negative response categories and apply a BERTopic model (Grootendorst 2022), implemented via the TextViz Studio application, to extract the topics mentioned in respondents' answers. TextViz Studio, developed by

one of our coauthors, is a flexible and efficient text analysis toolkit that automates complex analytical pipelines while allowing for advanced model configurations.⁶ This application facilitated the end-to-end implementation of BERTopic to our survey data, enabling topic discovery, visualization, and generating interpretable topic labels.

BERTopic generates topics by embedding responses into a semantic vector space, clustering semantically similar responses together, and extracting the most distinctive vocabulary for each cluster using a class-based Term Frequency-Inverse Document Frequency (TF-IDF) procedure (Grootendorst 2022). This approach differs from traditional bag-of-words topic models (e.g., LDA) in that clustering is driven by the contextual meaning of responses rather than word frequency alone, making it suitable for open-ended survey responses that can carry different meanings while using the same lexical expressions.

Following initial topic extractions, we conducted a consolidation step in which the resulting topics were reviewed qualitatively against their keywords and representative documents. Topics that were substantively redundant, representing the same underlying preference expressed with minor variations in phrasing, were merged into coherent groups. This consolidation was guided primarily by a close reading of topic content, followed by the use of a two-dimensional visualization showing inter-topic vocabulary distances. Following topic consolidation, GPT-5.5 was used to generate concise labels for each merged topic based on its pooled representative keywords and response documents, providing interpretable and consistent topic names for reporting.⁷

To assess the validity of the resulting topic structures, we examined topic distinctiveness using two complementary representations. First, we constructed an inter-topic distance map based on the vocabulary profiles of each topic, specifically the class-based TF-IDF vectors used by BERTopic to characterize each topic's distinctive terminology, and projected these to two dimensions for visualization. Second, we produced a parallel map using sentence embedding centroids, representing the average semantic meaning of all documents assigned to each topic in the same embedding space used during model fitting. In both representations, topics occupied visually distinct regions of the projected space, providing convergent evidence that the final topic solution captures substantively different themes rather than arbitrary partitions of a homogeneous response corpus.⁸

We also measured respondents' direct experiences with traffic stops and their overall perceptions of policing in Los Angeles. First, we asked respondents whether they

had recently experienced a traffic stop.⁹ Of our full (weighted) sample, 822 individuals reported having been recently stopped, 223 of whom were White, 71 were Black, 420 were Latine, 85 were Asian, and 23 were classified as “Other.” Of those who reported being stopped, we asked whether the officer who stopped them:

- Was comforting and reassuring
- Seemed trustworthy
- Was fair and even-handed
- Treated the respondent with dignity and respect

Respondents rated each outcome on a 5-point scale ranging from “strongly disagree” to “strongly agree,” with a neutral midpoint. These four items have a high degree of internal consistency when treated as numeric (Cronbach’s $\alpha = 0.93$), and we create an additive Positive Actions Index that measures the respondent’s perception of the officer’s behavior during the stop. The items of the index broadly track the four dimensions of procedural justice in policing research (Sunshine and Tyler 2003). Separately, we also asked respondents whether they viewed their stop as legitimate, which we code dichotomously as (1) if “Yes” or (0) if “No.”

In each wave, we also asked respondents about concrete negative actions they experienced from police during the traffic stop. These actions range from an officer shouting or swearing at the respondent to being handcuffed, having a gun pointed at them, or being removed from their vehicle. We detail each item and the full question wording in Appendix A. These items scale well across waves (June $\alpha = 0.79$, November $\alpha = 0.83$), and we create an additive index as with the Positive Actions Index.

We also measured respondents’ perceptions of overall policing effectiveness and legitimacy. Respondents were first asked to rate police performance on a 5-point scale from “very poor job” to “very good job” for the following three items:

In your opinion, how are police doing with:

- (1) Dealing with problems that concern your neighborhood
- (2) Fighting crime in your neighborhood
- (3) Treating people fairly regardless of who they are

Cronbach’s α indicates that these questions capture the same underlying concept ($\alpha = 0.89$), and we combine them into an Effectiveness Index, measuring respondents’ evaluation of local police effectiveness using the same procedure used above.

To measure overall police legitimacy, we use a previously validated index composed of eight survey items that tap into interrelated components of legitimacy,

including trust in police and perception of normative alignment of police-public values (i.e., the perception that one’s values are shared by the police) (see Peyton et al. 2019). In contrast to Peyton et al., we use a five-point scale rather than a seven-point scale for the index’s eight items. Cronbach’s α for these questions is 0.88, indicating a high degree of internal consistency. The exact question wording for each item and diagnostics for all indices are documented in Appendix A.

Interview Methods

Interview participants were recruited through social media, publicly posted fliers, posts on the “Nextdoor” app, and connections with Southern California community organizations. Interviews took place between July 2023 and September 2024 and were conducted in person or via online video conference. Thirty interviews were recorded with participant consent, then transcribed and de-identified with a unique code and pseudonym.¹⁰ Interviewee demographics for this set of interviews are displayed in Table 1.

Interviews lasted up to 1 hour and explored participants’ experiences with and perspectives on policing in Los Angeles and beyond. Specifically, participants were first asked to describe the neighborhoods they grew up in as well as the areas they currently reside in, and were encouraged to recount the racial and ethnic demographics of their neighborhood, levels of community closeness, walkability, other modes of transportation, and police presence. Participants then answered questions about their experiences with police, including their first, most recent, or most memorable interactions, their views on the Los Angeles Police Department, and preferences for how police would interact with them during motor vehicle stops.

Analysis of interview transcripts followed the issue-focused approach (Weiss 1994). First, using ATLAS.ti, interview transcripts were subjected to an initial round of coding by two independent coders who inductively coded themes broadly related to direct and vicarious experiences with police. These inductive codes were then collectively reviewed and reconciled to produce a new coding scheme focused on themes that emerged in the initial round of coding: desires, expectations, and treatment during police encounters. Using this revised coding scheme, coders then re-coded interviews.¹¹

Evaluating the Quality of Policy Representation in Los Angeles Policing

We now present our empirical findings related to policing. We demonstrate that descriptive patterns across

Table 1. Interview participant descriptive statistics

		Count	Percentage
Total		30	
Gender	Female	19	63.33
	Male	11	36.66
Race	Asian	4	13.33
	Black	8	26.67
	Latino	4	13.33
	Other/Mixed Race	2	6.67
	White	12	40.00
Highest level of education	Associates	1	3.33
	Bachelors	18	60.00
	High school	1	3.33
	Masters	4	13.33
	Some college	2	6.67
Sexual orientation	Doctorate	1	3.33
	Bisexual	2	6.67
	Heterosexual	21	70.00
	Homosexual	2	6.67
Ever worked in law enforcement?	Queer	1	3.33
	No	29	96.67
	Yes	1	3.33

Note. Totals may not sum due to omitted information by participants.

Los Angeles, presenting racial differences adjusted, when stated, for a minimal set of demographic covariates, but we do not attempt to identify a causal relationship in our analyses.

Overall Preferences for Police Behavior During Traffic Stops

We employ topic modeling on open-ended responses regarding the behavior people prefer to experience from the police during traffic stops. The results in [Table 2](#) show that in describing positive behaviors, 87% of responses describe calm, respectful communication from police officers. Responses in this category consistently emphasized dignity, composure, and mutual respect. One respondent captured the sentiment broadly, noting that officers should have “a nice tone voice” that makes the driver “feel comfortable” rather than intimidated, adding that “we are both human beings with feelings.” Others framed the preference in explicitly reciprocal terms, wanting officers to “treat me how they’d want to be treated” and to make the interaction feel calm rather than adversarial. A recurring theme within this dominant category was the desire not to be treated as a criminal or spoken to in a condescending or authoritative way, with one respondent asking simply to be “treated like a person.”

Beyond the general preference for respectful treatment, 7% of respondents specifically wanted officers to

explain the reason for the stop clearly and directly. Rather than being asked “do you know why I stopped you,” respondents in this category preferred officers to communicate the specific reason for the stop themselves, in a polite tone, and in some cases to issue a warning rather than a citation where appropriate. Smaller proportions expressed preferences for a polite professional tone akin to a service interaction. One respondent described wanting “a professional tone of voice, like with a bank teller or a doctor, not demanding or loud” and for officers to open the interaction with a friendly greeting, such as saying hello or waving, which respondents described as making the encounter feel approachable from the outset. One percent of respondents also expressed a preference specifically related to physical conduct, wanting officers to keep their weapon holstered unless a clear threat was present, pairing this with a desire for calm and non-threatening body language throughout the stop.

In response to survey items about what they do not want officers to say or do, responses were similarly concentrated across a small number of related topics, reflecting broad agreement about unwanted police conduct during traffic stops. The largest share of respondents, 44%, expressed that they do not want officers to be generally aggressive or disrespectful in their approach. Responses in this category described wanting to avoid rudeness, intimidation, and the misuse of authority, with one respondent noting they would not want an officer “to be rude or intimidating as they have more power” nor to put their hands on them without cause. A further 19% of

Table 2. Topic proportions across response categories

Category	Topic	Percentage of responses
Positive behaviors	Calm respectful communication	87%
	Explain stop reason clearly	7%
	Friendly greeting and waving	1%
	Keep weapon holstered	1%
	Misc.	3%
	Polite professional tone	1%
Negative behaviors	Abusive yelling or insults	11%
	Aggression or disrespect	44%
	Forceful shouting or demands	8%
	Hostile threatening conduct	7%
	Misc.	7%
	Profiling or baseless arrest	2%
	Rude ticketing	2%
	Weapons or forceful removal	19%

Note. Misc. topics contain responses that did not relate to preferences for traffic stop communication and actions. The pool of adult survey respondents was weighted to Los Angeles City population benchmarks derived from U.S. Census data for age, race, and education.

respondents expressed concern specifically about unwanted physical conduct, including officers drawing their weapons without cause or forcibly removing them from their vehicles. One respondent described not wanting officers to “pull me from my car, scream at me, pull a gun, or have a taser out for no reason,” capturing the physical dimension of unwanted conduct that this group of respondents emphasized.

Approximately 11% of respondents specifically identified abusive yelling or insults as unwanted behavior, while 8% focused on forceful shouting or unreasonable demands. A smaller proportion, 7%, expressed concern about hostile or threatening conduct more broadly, including aggressive tone, sharp body movements, and accusatory behavior from the outset of the stop. Two percent of respondents identified racial profiling and baseless arrest as specific concerns, with responses noting they would not want to be treated differently on the basis of race or to have an officer be “on alert” when reaching for a wallet. As with the positive topics, the concentration of responses across a limited number of related themes indicates substantial shared sentiment among Los Angeles respondents about the kinds of officer conduct they find most objectionable.

Homogeneous Preferences for Police Behavior During Traffic Stops

Next, we assess potential heterogeneity in preferences with an analysis of topic proportions across racial groups (see [Figure 1](#)). Our results show little variation across racial groups. Across Asian, Black, Hispanic, and White respondents, the proportion of responses expressing a

preference for calm, respectful communication ranged narrowly from 84% to 88%, and the proportion identifying aggression or disrespect as an unwanted behavior ranged from 42% to 48%. To formally assess whether these proportions differed significantly from White respondents, who served as the reference group, we estimated a series of weighted logistic regressions with each topic as a binary outcome and race as the predictor. With two marginal exceptions ($p < 0.1$), no statistically significant differences emerged, and given the number of comparisons, we would expect some differences to occur by chance.¹²

Regardless of a respondent’s race, a supermajority of Los Angeles residents want officers to be calm and professional during a traffic stop and not engage in aggressive behavior.

Taken together, our topic modeling illustrates the public’s desire for interactions characterized by professionalism, calmness, and respect. There is also a clear, shared aversion to aggressive and authoritarian behaviors. Our results are in line with decades of research demonstrating that people value procedural justice in policing ([Sunshine and Tyler 2003](#); [Tyler 2005](#)) and that individuals report greater satisfaction when officers explain their reasoning clearly and engage in respectful dialogue ([Mazerolle et al. 2013](#)).

Policy Implementation: Police Actions During Traffic Stops

Policy representation hinges on the (dis)connection between people’s policy preferences and what they receive from the government. In the context of studying traffic stops, we know that there are a large number of written policies and procedures guiding officer behavior, but the

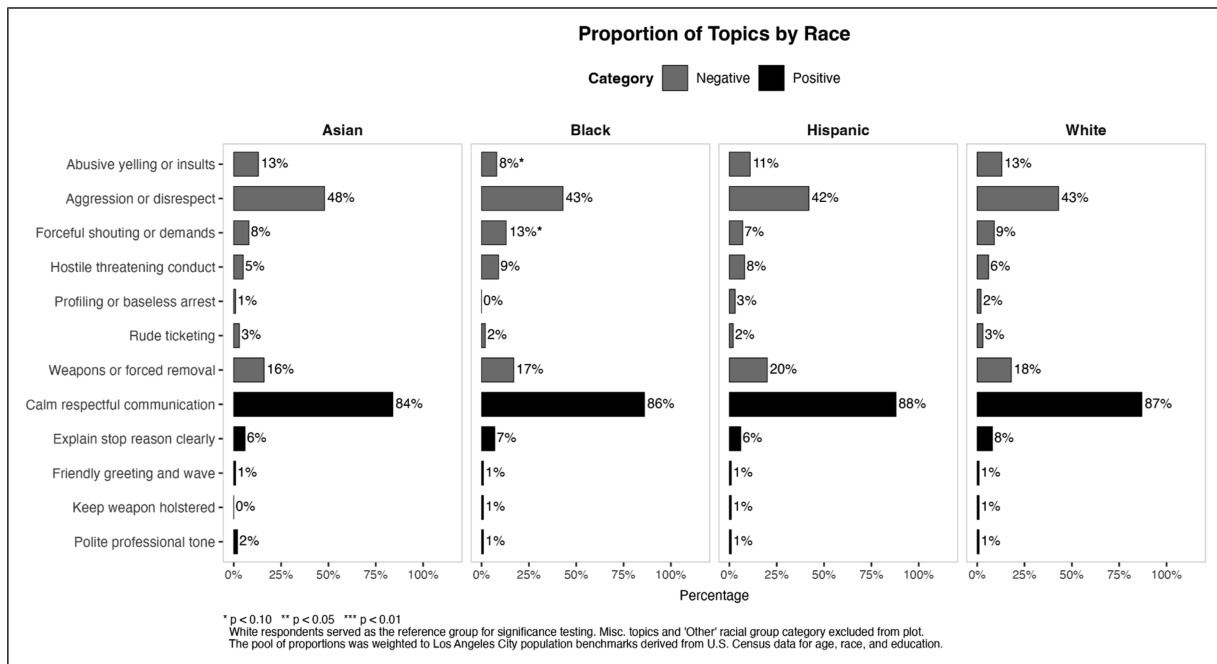


Figure 1. Topic proportions response categories by racial group.

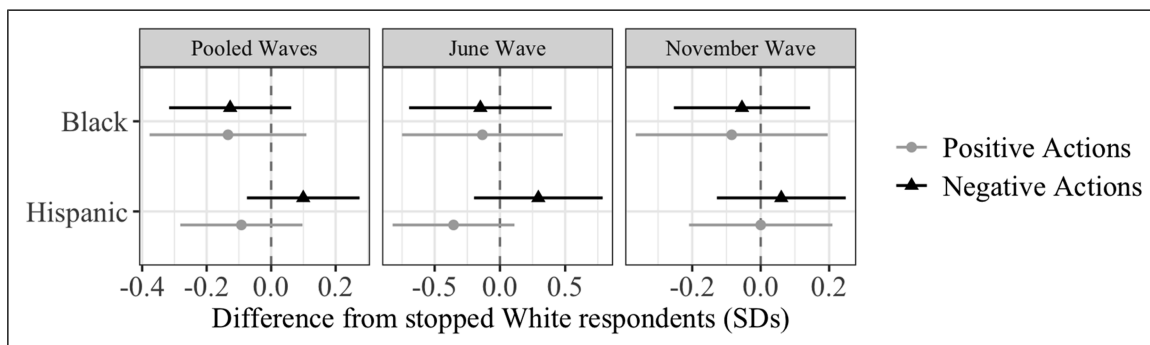
policy people experience hinges on how officers actually behave in practice.

To examine how respondents' experiences with traffic stops vary across racial groups, we regress the Positive and Negative Action Indices on respondent race via survey-weighted OLS, with fixed effects for survey wave and bins for age, education, and income. Each race coefficient is the difference in standard deviations relative to the reference group, adjusted for these covariates. In each of our analyses, we compare responses for Black and Hispanic respondents against those of White respondents.¹³

The results of these models are presented in the leftmost panel in Figure 2. The average differences in

both indices are close to zero and statistically insignificant, indicating that there is no difference in the two indices as reported by respondents during their traffic stops. The lack of a racial difference in the two action indices is somewhat unexpected given research that documents racial disparities in police stops (Gelman et al. 2007; Kramer and Remster 2018; Pierson et al. 2020) and less respectful officer treatment of Black drivers during traffic stops (Voigt et al. 2017), but those studies also use different measures than our study.

Despite differences from prior work, our null results appear to accurately reflect the Los Angeles setting. First, much of the evidence about racial disparities in policing looks at different actions than we do (e.g., the



stop decision, searches, or use of violence), and most of the studies are also not about Los Angeles. Second, in the first survey wave in November 2023, we asked respondents if they had experienced a traffic stop and then about what happened during the stop; however, in the June 2024 survey, we asked specifically about a stop within the last 6 months. The center and rightmost panel in Figure 2 suggest the results do not vary materially across either the recency of the traffic stop or when the survey was fielded. Though our coefficients are larger for Hispanic respondents in June they are imprecise due to the small sample of stopped respondents in that wave. In essence, our June 2024 wave serves as a replication of the result from the November 2023 wave and increases confidence that the result is not simply recall bias.

Employing the same controls, we also fail to uncover differences in the perceived legitimacy of the stop by race, which we asked in our November wave, with both Black (beta = -0.08 , $p = 0.25$) and Hispanic (beta = -0.04 , $p = 0.44$) drivers reporting similar rates of legitimacy as White drivers, with the differences in the expected direction, but having a large amount of uncertainty. Over 60% of stopped respondents of all races report their stop as legitimate.

We next examine whether what happens in the traffic stop affects perceptions of stop/police legitimacy, for which we expect a positive relationship based on research about procedural justice (Sunshine and Tyler 2003). The Positive Action Index is related to both Stop Legitimacy and Overall Legitimacy of the police, as shown in Figures 3 and 4. We estimate that a one standard deviation increase in the Positive Action Index is associated with an almost 30 percentage point higher probability of a stop being seen as legitimate, and the estimated relationship is essentially the same across racial groups (Figure 3). The index is also positively associated with our measure of overall police legitimacy, though attenuated for Black respondents (Figure 4). It is worth noting that these are the expected patterns, but the direction of causality is difficult to assess. Although it makes sense that positive actions improve legitimacy, it is also possible that those who

view police as more legitimate also see an officer's actions as more positive (i.e., reverse causality) or that these concepts reinforce each other (i.e., simultaneity bias).

There is considerable research about racial differences in overall perceptions of police and policing (Lerman and Weaver 2014; Payne Center for Social Justice and Gallup 2023), and therefore, we also collected data about respondents' perceptions of police effectiveness and legitimacy. We identify significant, meaningful differences between White and non-White respondents in perceptions of police legitimacy and effectiveness in Figure 5. White respondents express more positive views toward the police than Black or Hispanic respondents across both outcome measures. We also subset the analyses to only those who reported experiencing a traffic stop, and we find the same basic pattern. This analysis further increases our confidence that our former results on preferences and experiences are not idiosyncratic, as the same subset of people who report little to no differences in treatment by police during their most recent encounter still see the police as less effective, suggesting on this outcome that there isn't something different about those who reported stop experiences.

Across a variety of quantitative outcomes and analyses, we find that what people report police doing during traffic stops does not differ substantially along racial lines once adjusting for education, age, and income.¹⁴ These results suggest that, in this domain, the quality of policy representation in the context of traffic stops might be largely similar across racial groups in Los Angeles. In contrast, consistent with patterns observed elsewhere in the country, we find that non-White respondents have significantly more negative views of the police overall, which would suggest that the quality of policy representation differs across races.

Understanding Expectations of and Experience With Police

An important possible explanation for the differences in overall perceptions of police, despite similarity in

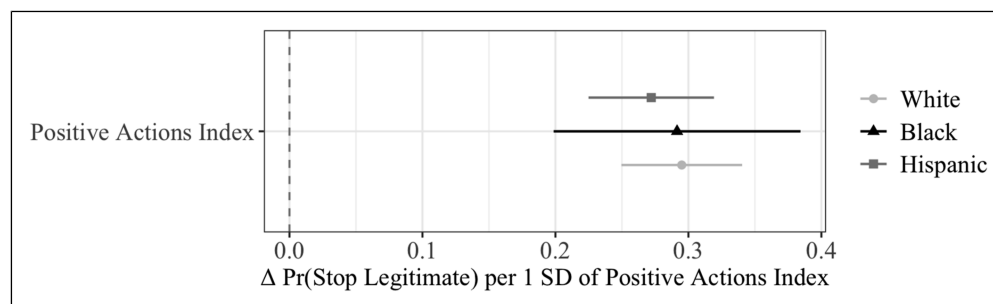


Figure 3. Positive actions predict stop legitimacy. *Each model included fixed effects for Education, Income, and Age (in bins).

preferences for policing and similar actions during traffic stops, is that people's opinions are affected by both their own and others' prior experiences with the state. As suggested by the literature on policy feedback, interactions with government agencies have a noticeable and lasting impact on people's perceptions of that agency (e.g., Lerman and McCabe 2017). Consistent with this work, Figure 6 shows that multiple instances of past unfair treatment by police (compared to no reported unfair treatment), as reported by the survey respondents, are highly predictive of views on police legitimacy, and this holds across racial groups.

Given the impact of experience on assessments of the quality of policy outcomes, if certain groups are more likely to have negative direct or vicarious experiences in the past, then we would expect to see a difference in their perceptions of policy implementation and quality, even if there is no difference across actions from their most recent stop. Racial variations in vicarious experience are manifested in well-known phrases such as "Driving While Black." More systematically, in a 2023 Gallup survey, approximately 30% of Black, 20% of Hispanic, and 10% of White respondents reported an unfair experience with police in the last year (Payne Center for Social Justice and Gallup 2023). Our survey data reveals similar patterns: 14% of White respondents report being repeatedly treated unfairly by the police in the past, compared to 30% of Black respondents and 24% of Hispanic respondents. Thus, even if the reported actions of officers appear to be the same across racial groups during a recent traffic stop, the context of and expectations around those actions differ in important ways, and as Figure 6 shows, these experiences are related to current opinions. We now turn to the second element of our mixed-methods project—semi-structured interviews with community members—to investigate more deeply previous experiences with policing and how those experiences relate to contemporary opinions.

Interview Results

Racial Differences in Expectations of Negative Interactions With Police

Our interview data provide insight into how past direct and vicarious experiences shape preferences for police behavior and affect the experience of police interactions. We observe significant differences across races in interviewees' expectations of the potential costs of interactions with the police, particularly the possibility of being subjected to police violence. Interviewees' responses reveal considerable variation in interviewees' feelings about police contact during traffic stops. Namely, Black and Latine drivers report direct

and vicarious experiences with police that inform contemporary fear and anxiety during traffic stops, including concerns of injury and death. White respondents, by comparison, did not report strong feelings of fear or anxiety regarding physical violence during traffic stops.

When asked about their preferences for being greeted during a traffic stop and being given a reason for the traffic stop, for example, multiple Black respondents expressed a lack of familiarity with such interactions, even confusion. Elijah, a Black man in his mid-thirties, responded, "That's such a foreign concept. I've never had that happen. Like what do you mean?" Samuel, a Black man in his twenties, suggested that the lack of a greeting during police interactions was an intentionally aggressive tactic used by police.

It seems like it's intentionally supposed to put you in a state of confusion, and like a little bit out of sorts...like you don't have a name to even associate with this shadowy being that is now shining a light into your car so you can barely even see their face. It definitely feels like a very aggressive tactic.

When further probed about safety, Black respondents provided nuanced responses that suggest these measures of respect are superseded by other concerns, including their physical well-being. Corey, a Black physician in his thirties, described in no uncertain terms that he feared for his safety—indeed, his very life—when interacting with police.

I don't want to get shot...that sounds very dark and I don't want to have to think about it but, that is the worst outcome. It's like you could get shot and die, or disabled. That is actually a more common outcome that we don't talk about as much but, yeah, you could lose a limb.

During the interview, Corey also drew on his experience as a physician to consider how police might assuage fear and distrust of the police in the way a physician might allay a Black patient's historically informed distrust of hospitals and medical professionals. As he concluded, however, he was unsure if something as simple as a greeting could counteract long-standing feelings of fear and distrust that many Black people feel toward police. He explained:

I hear Black women say this all the time: 'I'm afraid of dying when I'm pregnant or when I'm giving birth.' And I want to assuage those fears as much as I can as a doctor...and I think maybe having someone be polite to me at the beginning of the encounter that is otherwise shaped by historical distrust would probably contribute to assuaging some concerns. In reality, would it? I don't know.

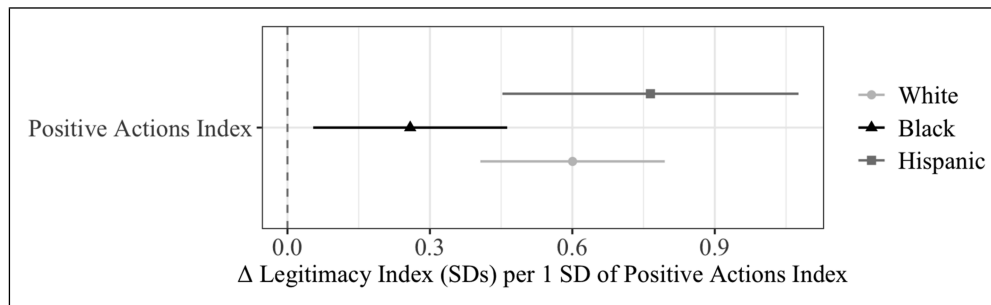


Figure 4. Positive actions predict legitimacy of police. *Each model included fixed effects for Education, Income, and Age (in bins).

Other respondents of color, like Isabella, a Latine woman in her 30s, were preoccupied with what police might do “next” after initial contact. Though she did not explicitly cite fear of police brutality, she described keen awareness of the behaviors and body language of officers who approach residents in “her area,” a historically and still predominantly Latine section of Los Angeles.

...what I see in my area is, [the police] approach vehicles very hostile...with their hands already on their service weapons. And so that creates some type of feeling with the driver where they don't want to comply and they don't want to roll the window down because they're afraid of the possibility of what can happen next. So I think the way that they initially jump out of the car, the way that they approach the vehicle, the body language that they use, like, it's critical in everything that can happen next.

Even before an officer speaks to her or makes physical contact, Isabella is vigilant for visual cues (e.g., officers touching their firearms) that might indicate the direction of an interaction with police. For her, it is the fear of uncertain but very costly outcomes that engenders behaviors (e.g., not rolling down a car window) commonly interpreted by police as “noncompliance” (Engel et al.

2012). In practice, the fear of officers' capacity for violence felt by Isabella and other respondents of color informs actions that, if perceived by officers as signs of a potential threat (Sierra-Arévalo 2024), can motivate officers to use the violence that informed residents' fear in the first place.

Corey and Isabella's responses contrast sharply with those of White respondents who did not report concern for their physical safety during interactions with police. This is not to say that other interviewees did not feel anxious about police interaction. Rather, their anxieties did not extend to the specific consideration of injury or death.

Noah, a White man in his thirties, described feeling anxious about his considerations of the possibility of various law enforcement actions.

Well... a lot of the anxiety also comes from like, am I going to get arrested? Am I getting a ticket? Am I going to get pulled out of my car? Are they going to try and search me? Or are they just sniffing around to try and find a reason, you know, to do any of that.

Noah considered a host of negative outcomes that might result from a traffic stop, including being fined,

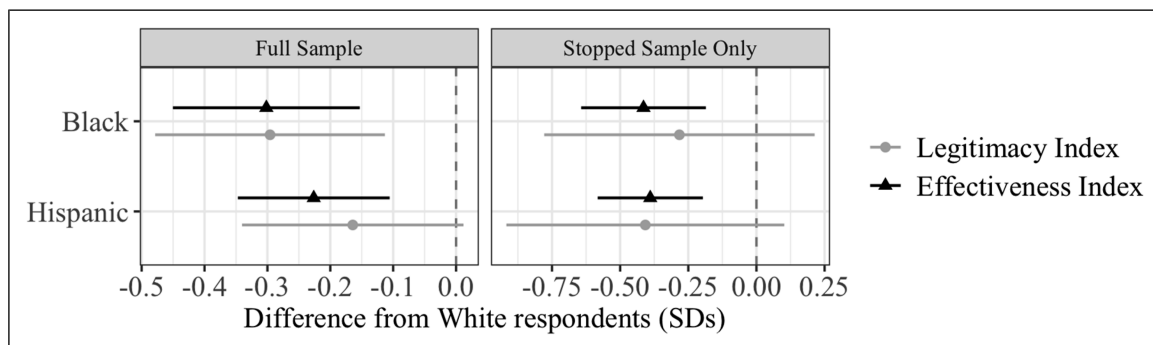


Figure 5. Racial differences in holistic views of police. *Coefficients represent adjusted differences from White Respondents in standard deviations. Each model includes fixed effects for Education, Income, Age (in bins), and Wave fixed effects are used in the pooled analysis.

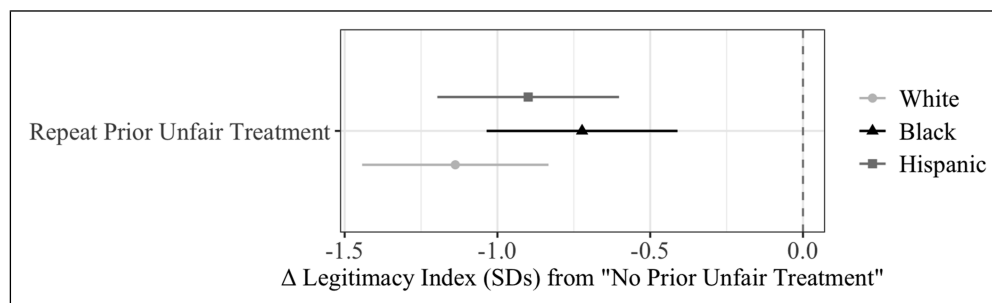


Figure 6. Police legitimacy as a function of past unfair treatment. *Each model controls for Education, Income, and Age (in bins).

searched, or arrested. He also mentioned the possibility of officers engaging in these enforcement actions as part of a pretextual stop, wherein officers officially cite a legal reason for their traffic stop to engage in unrelated investigatory activity. The possibility that they might be beaten, shot, or killed by police, however, was not mentioned by Noah nor any other non-Black, non-Latine interviewee.

This does not mean, however, that non-Black and non-Latine interviewees were unaware of the existence of racial disparities in police treatment, including police violence. On the contrary, multiple interviewees discussed that racial minorities, in particular Black and Latine people, were treated differently by police than White people.

Grace, a White woman in her late twenties, explained that when she and her non-White boyfriend have to interact with the police, she takes advantage of her race and gender to mitigate the possibility of the situation becoming violent.

She stated, “Anytime we talk to the police, like, I always talk to them. I think I know very well that [being] White and a woman helps me not have a negative interaction compared to [my boyfriend].” She also stipulated that she would only ever call the police if there were conditions of acute threat, such as a burglary. When asked why she would hesitate to call the police otherwise, she again cited her perception of racial minorities being at greater risk of being subjected to police violence:

Once the police are involved, there’s a higher likelihood that people that don’t look like me are at higher risk. So that’s why, if I were to call them, it would need to be a very high risk for my safety because knowing that they’re just around, therefore people of color and people at risk are at higher risk...of police violence.

Likewise, Kelsie, a White woman in her early twenties, reported that she believed “a lot of negative interactions with cops are against minorities or ... people who might appear to be of a lower socioeconomic status.”

She recalled a traffic stop in which she was the passenger of a vehicle being driven by another White woman.

I definitely think [race] factored in at least a bit because, you know, we’re both White women. She was driving a nicer car, so I definitely think that that played a factor, whether it was consciously or subconsciously with the cop.

In addition to gender and race, Kelsie explicitly noted that class—signaled by the type of car her friend drove—may have shaped the interaction she and her friend had during a traffic stop. By contrast, she believes that “negative interactions” with police often involve individuals who are “minorities” or “of a lower socioeconomic status.” Like all other White respondents, she made no mention of fearing the possibility of injury or death at the hands of police during a traffic stop.

Racial Differences in Exposure to Police

Our interview data provide evidence that observed racial differences in expectations of police interactions are related to prior experiences with police. In keeping with research on legal socialization and perceptions of police (e.g., Hughes et al. 2006), Black and Latine interviewees described direct and vicarious experiences with police that shaped their attitudes and expectations regarding police contact.

Direct Exposure. Multiple interviewees of color recalled direct, routine, and anxiety-inducing contact with police in their communities. For example, Henry, a 37-year-old Latine man, described being stopped by police as “a passage or rite” of growing up in Los Angeles. He recalled feeling targeted by police who aggressively questioned him during a stop of a friend’s vehicle in which he was a passenger.

I had an anxiety-ridden encounter where I was riding passenger in the backseat of my friend’s car. And the car just

happened to call too much attention because it was hand painted, spray painted with art and stuff like that. So it didn't even take more than two to three minutes from pulling out of the driveway, in the same neighborhood, and then being pulled over, and getting flashlights, you know, shoved in the face, like getting the windows knocked on and tapped on like all aggressively. And just like the most insane probing and eye locking like staring contest, and it's just so it is uncalming. ... They're trying to, like, provoke something or see something. ... I was asked, like, why are you in the back of the seat? Why are you not wearing a seatbelt? Who are you? What are you doing? ... There's just too many probing questions ... you could have just asked for identification. They would have known everything. ... I just felt targeted. ... Like, I can't even be in my own neighborhood. Or in a car.

Elijah, who now lives in Los Angeles but grew up in Chicago, also recounted him and his friends being regularly stopped by police as children, including while riding a bicycle or in a friend's car. These experiences, he said, were foundational to his present-day distrust of police:

That shit starts early. ... They really become foundational and hard to move. So, I cannot see a world where I'm cool with cops as a 35-year-old man...Even still, I would never want to be seen talking to a police officer. I would never want to be seen and like associated with a police officer because of...what me and my friends experienced growing up.

Crucially, these early experiences with police also inform experiences and expectations of police interactions in the present. Elijah described various behavioral strategies he's adopted in light of his learned fear of police and the possibility of being injured or killed by them.

Always have your hands present, articulate to the best of your ability... Like defensive driving has a whole different meaning if you're Black, like I'm always surveilling my perimeter. I feel like as a Black male driver, I always have a sixth sense of where the cops are and I'm always trying to present like I'm very aware of the rules of the road. I have to be on defense. [...] It's an unsettling experience every single time. ... I hate it, like, my stomach drops. ... I've really got to breathe deep. It's always "Yes, sir. No, sir. Yes, Mr. Officer." Like, I'm going above and beyond ... I just don't want to put it in [the police officer's] head. Like, I am not a threat.

As a result of multiple negative interactions with police, Elijah views contemporary police interactions as inherently threatening. Today, he is preoccupied with keeping track of police presence and avoiding contact with police through "defensive driving." When he does interact with police, he reports keeping his hands visible,

working to stay calm, and being politely deferential to avoid being interpreted by police as a threat.

By contrast, other respondents' prior police interactions did not engender feelings of anxiety or fear regarding their physical safety. Ella, a White woman in her 40s, did recall being ticketed during a traffic stop and being upset because she could not afford the fine. Nonetheless, she also cited her race and gender as helping insulate her from disrespect during police interactions.

As a White lady, I implicitly expect to be treated with respect and not have much of a problem. I cannot say that the same is true for everyone in my life, who is not White. It's a completely different experience.

Ella's prior contact with police was unremarkable. Rather than feeling distrust or anxiety, she expected to be treated with respect during police interactions and to "not have much of a problem." She went so far as to contrast this with what she believed to be the experience of people who are not White women. The responses of multiple Black and Latine interviewees, who reported negative interactions with police, support her perception of these racialized differences in police interaction.

Vicarious Exposure—Family and Media. Along with direct experiences with police, our interview data show that experiences of police interactions in the present are informed by vicarious exposures to police contact. Building on prior research that attends to vicarious exposure through peers or neighbors (Brunson 2007; Harris and Jones 2020; Rosenbaum et al. 2005), we explore two other vectors through which interviewees described vicarious exposure to police contact: family exposure and media.

Prior research documents that families are a mechanism for the intergenerational transmission of police-related knowledge, often referred to as "the talk." During this "talk," Black parents or elders give younger generations lessons regarding how to avoid police contact and police violence in response to a historical pattern of racialized state surveillance and abuse (Malone Gonzalez 2019).

Elijah described examples of these lessons that were passed down to him by his father while growing up in Chicago. He recalled being warned by his father about being out after dark in [Mount] Greenwood, an area in south Chicago with a high concentration of White, working class residents. This area, according to Elijah's father, was akin to a "sundown town," a reference to towns which historically used intimidation and violence to prevent the residence and even presence of Black people, especially after dark (O'Connell 2019).

My dad was like, ‘I’d rather have you in the heart of the ‘hood at one, two o’clock in the morning than in [...] Greenwood’... It’s all cops, firemen, all White folks. He’s like, ‘That’s the sundown town [...] I don’t want you to be over there when the sun goes down. I don’t want you to be driving over there really at all if you don’t need to be.

Notably, Elijah’s father’s invocation of “sundown towns” reflects the historical and racialized concern with police common to Black Americans. More precisely, it evidences the salience of historic patterns of anti-Blackness that extend to more localized, anti-Black “police neighborhoods” like Mount Greenwood (see [Fox 2025](#)).

Audrey, a young Black woman in her twenties, also described how early lessons learned from her parents informed how she navigated a traffic stop that occurred on her way home from college. During the stop, she explained, “I immediately—you know, my parents taught me—I called the police station like, ‘Hey, this is me. I was speeding. I’m sorry. Can you make sure I don’t die?’ And then I called my mom, and she’s on the phone, so... there’s definitely a whole training that you get as a child to make sure you make it through those interactions unhurt or unharmed.”

The intergenerational, familial exposure to police described by Black interviewees stands in sharp contrast to that described by White interviewees. Emily, a White woman in her 20s, grew up in an affluent, suburban community on the East Coast. Her earliest memories of police were uneventful and unrelated to enforcement: an officer’s “stranger danger” presentation at her elementary school, and an officer who responded to her home for a medical emergency.

Now a resident of Santa Monica, an affluent, beachside area of Los Angeles, she contrasted the experiences of her non-White friends with her early lessons about police. “I remember talking to some friends...and them saying when they were growing up [they] were taught by their parents not to go to the police.” Emily contrasted this to lessons she was taught in her family: “My parents always told me if you get lost, if you need help, whatever, find a police officer...that [was] a really big ‘wow’ moment for all of us thinking about how differently we had been taught about the police.”

In addition to the intergenerational transmission of vicarious police exposure, interviewees also described vicarious exposure to high-profile cases of police violence. Interviewees’ responses indicate that, in addition to the opinion-mobilizing effects of such “focusing events” ([Birkland 1998](#); [Reny and Newman 2021](#)), high-profile cases of police violence inform Black people’s fears of injury or death at the hands of police. Some of the cases mentioned by interviewees occurred in places to which interviewees had a direct connection; others did not.

Regardless, high-profile cases of police violence reinforced the understanding of police as a historically consistent threat to the physical safety of Black Americans.

Sophia, a Black woman in her 50s, recalled the recent case of Tyre Nichols, a young Black man who was beaten to death by police in her hometown of Memphis, Tennessee. This police killing garnered tremendous media attention and, as Sophia reported, informed conversations about police within her family. The case also proved that there is always a possibility that one of her male family members might be arrested or killed by police, regardless of the propriety of their behavior. She explained:

Having nephews that are still in [Memphis] and still in their 20s and 30s, that has been a conversation that has come up. ... You always keep bail money or you keep money for funerals. ... Even when you do everything right and you cross every T and dot every I, there’s always a possibility of there being an interaction between one of my nephews, or one of my brothers, or one of my uncles, and a member of the police force.

Likewise, Corey referred to several high-profile police brutality cases as being top of mind while driving. He said, “You just never know. Like, being exposed to stories of people getting pulled over, like, you know, Sandra Bland. You just—it feels, even if statistically I probably am gonna be fine, you just never know, like, if today is your day.” This pervasive fear among families of color, and specifically Black families, is reinforced by incidents of police violence amplified through media channels.

Several participants also referred to the highly publicized murder of George Floyd, describing political awakenings to the potential of deadly police encounters that people of color face. Grace reflected on the 2020 protests, “I, because of my very privileged bubble growing up, didn’t really have to interact with the police. I’ve realized how truly scary they can be... I think that through 2020 seeing some of the interactions with them - I luckily did not experience anything personal...but I was very close to those moments.” For Elijah, that particular political moment was insulting in some ways. He said, “as a Black man you kind of feel like ‘Welcome to the party’”. Similarly, James, a White man originally from Germany, described the orientation he received before moving to Los Angeles, “I would say, you know, in when you come to the US... the one thing that you hear in Germany even from official agencies, [is] be very careful if you get stopped by the police, in the US it’s very different.”

Our interviews with LA residents show that interviewees’ prior experiences with police, both direct or vicarious, inform their present-day view of and

interactions with police. Crucially, the relationship between prior direct and vicarious experiences with police varies across interviewee races. Whether through their own direct experience, legal socialization within their families, or by way of media exposure, Black and Latine interviewees described how prior experiences with police influenced their view of interactions with police in the present day. In particular, Black and Latine interviewees described anxiety and fear for their physical safety during interactions with police. Though some White respondents expressed the belief that non-White people faced a higher risk of mistreatment by police than they did, no White interviewee expressed fear for their physical safety when interacting with police.

These qualitative findings provide important context for our quantitative survey results, which indicate similar preferences for officer behavior during traffic stops. Across all racial groups, there is a consistent desire for officers to behave respectfully during traffic stops. But unlike White and Asian respondents, the desire for respect during traffic stops among Black and Latine respondents comes apace with anxiety and fear of police. Thus, *even when respondents from different communities desire the same officer behavior*, they may value it for different reasons, and *even when officers conduct themselves similarly*, drivers with different backgrounds may experience those stops very differently.

As is the case for any given research study, there are several limitations to our data that bear acknowledgment. First, our results are based on a study conducted in Los Angeles, and the city may differ from other cities in ways that affect both stop-level experiences and general police assessments. Still, Los Angeles is a large, diverse metropolitan area with well-known conflicts between police and civilians. We would expect this context to be similar to many other urban contexts in the United States, and our ability to replicate many common patterns from other areas provides evidence that Los Angeles is not generally different from other studied areas and suggests that our argument here is applicable in other, similar contexts.

Second, our interview sample, while diverse, is small and may have non-representative views on or experiences with policing.

Third, our research design does not allow us to establish causality, either between prior experiences, recent experiences, and attitudes, or by race. Our data about officer actions during a stop are necessarily conditional on a stop being reported by a respondent. Black and Hispanic drivers may be stopped more often and for different reasons, which is an important part of policy representation, but is not something we capture in our research design. It may also be that the type of Los Angeles residents who participate in an online poll are unrepresentative of Los Angeles residents in general, and that

may partially explain the absence of estimated racial differences from our survey.

Fourth, we do not directly observe what officers do during stops. Our measures of positive and negative officer actions rely on respondent recall, which may itself be shaped by the very expectations and fears our interviews reveal. These are real constraints on what data like ours can establish, and it is certainly worth using other methods, such as analysis of body-worn camera recordings (Rho et al. 2023; Voigt et al. 2017), to study whether officers treat drivers differently by race during traffic stops.

Despite these limitations, our integrated mixed-methods approach offers a nuanced understanding of racial inequality by uncovering how similar bureaucratic encounters can be experienced in fundamentally different ways. By connecting broad survey patterns with deep qualitative insights, we reveal that the true weight of unequal policing often lies in the divergent expectations and experiences that citizens bring to interactions.

Discussion and Conclusion

Los Angeles residents across racial groups report similar preferences for respectful policing and similar treatment during recent stops, yet diverge sharply in holistic assessments of police and accumulated experiences. Our interviews suggest that the preference for respectful behavior is held against different backdrops of fear and experience. For Black and Latine residents, professionalism is a matter of physical safety; for White residents, it is a matter of courtesy. Furthermore, overall assessments of policing are built from both direct and vicarious experiences that differ across racial groups. This implies that representation in face-to-face bureaucratic encounters is shaped not just by official behavior, but by the historical expectations and psychological experiences citizens bring to the interaction.

This finding has direct implications for how scholars study racial inequality in policing and its relationship to policy representation. More specifically, studying policy representation requires measuring what citizens receive from the government and attending not only to the formal content of policy or even to reported bureaucratic behavior, but also to how citizens interpret and experience those interactions. As Soss (1999) shows in the context of welfare administration, and as Mettler and Soss (2004) argue more broadly, the way citizens experience policy, beyond its formal content, shapes their beliefs about government responsiveness and their political engagement. Our results extend this argument to policing and suggest that survey measures of encounter quality may fail to capture the most consequential dimension of racial inequality: not consistently different actions based on race, but that interactions carry different meanings and impose

different psychological costs, depending on what the person being stopped has learned to expect. A stop that registers as unremarkable for one driver may register as a survival event for another.

Our data establish that understanding racial inequality in policing and the quality of policy representation more broadly requires methods that can capture what residents bring to encounters, not only what happens during them. Our survey and our interviews each illuminate different aspects of this problem, and together they suggest that neither approach alone is sufficient. The racial gaps that appear in general assessments of police, and that are absent in our stop-level survey reports, are not necessarily contradictory findings. They may reflect the same underlying reality: that routine police contact is experienced differently across racial groups in ways that shape lasting orientations toward government, even when the surface features of individual encounters look similar. Taking representation seriously in contexts where policy is delivered through face-to-face interactions between officials and citizens requires measuring not only the interaction itself, but the history and expectations that each party brings to it.

Authors Notes

Sierra-Arévalo is the lead author—he led the qualitative analysis and contributed significantly to the theory and writing. Alcocer conducted the topic modeling and contributed to theory. Brown contributed primarily to the interview research. Delorme contributed primarily to the qualitative analysis. Friedman contributed to the qualitative analysis and theory. Graham contributed to theory, writing, and data collection. Muttram conducted the analysis of the survey data and contributed to theory, writing, and conceptualization. Trager contributed primarily to theory. Weller is the senior author—he led the paper overall, contributing across all elements.

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Data Availability Statement

Replication data is available at <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/MHG3A9>, Harvard Dataverse. (Sierra-Arévalo et al. 2026).

Supplemental Material

Supplemental material for this article is available online.

Notes

1. Showing the broad applicability of the role of SLB interactions in shaping government legitimacy, Jap (2024) finds that simple, positive bureaucratic interactions can significantly enhance minority citizens' allegiance to the government.
2. Scholars argue that repeated contact with courts, prisons, and police socially label racial and ethnic minorities as inherently deviant, criminal and suspect. Over time, the assumed criminality of minority groups becomes both normalized and "embodied" (Friedman and Hitchens 2021), shaping "perpetual encounters" with police that affect individual wellbeing (Deckard et al. 2025; Sewell and Jefferson 2016; Sugie and Turney 2017).
3. For details on subject anonymity and compliance with ethical principles of human subjects research, see Appendix D.
4. More information about PrimePanels is provided in Appendix A.
5. We concatenated verbal and action responses for positive and negative prompts, resulting in two primary categories: positive and negative preferences. We then removed all rows with missing data across any response categories.
6. TextViz Studio can be accessed through the following Streamlit application link under the "Text2Topics" module: <https://textvizstudio.streamlit.app/>.
7. Full technical details and methodology are provided in Appendix B.
8. These Figures are presented in Appendix B.
9. The exact wording of the question differed slightly in each wave: the first asked whether a respondent had ever been stopped, while the second asked whether a stop had occurred in the last 6 months. We use the latter as a replication exercise, focusing on a stop that should still be memorable for the respondent.
10. Interviews were part of a larger effort to collect qualitative data on police-community member interactions. In total, 54 people were interviewed—24 of these interviews were not audio recorded and generated only handwritten notes. To ensure our analysis draws on the highest-fidelity measurements, we use only the 30 interviews which were audio recorded.
11. See Appendix C for supplemental information about the interviews.
12. See Appendix B for a full discussion of results.

13. Due to small sample sizes, we omit coefficients for Asian and “Other” respondents.
14. In [Appendix A](#), we replicate each of the primary analysis presented here, instead collapsing respondent races into “White” or “Black or Latino.” Our results again recover limited differences, guarding further against concerns that nulls are driven by a lack of power.

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